environment, and did so for over a millennium. Perhaps the elements got worse over time, but why did they choose this struggle? With the area's water resources clearly not ideal for agriculture, what economic activity could have driven the city's fortunes and sustained people for centuries in this harsh environment? Some scholars believe that Dholavira was a regional hub of maritime trade and commerce (the Rann was then navigable to the Arabian Sea and beyond).

The Harappans traded internally and with others, both overland and on waterways. Porters and bullock carts moved goods overland. From the sea near Dholavira, ships went upriver to Harappa with salted and/or dried marine catfish. They sourced raw materials from far and wide: copper, shell, semi-precious stones. Skilled artisans must have travelled often, spreading similar technologies and fads. Going by discovered seals, beads and weights, the Harappans also traded with Sumer and Akkad in Mesopotamia, and with Dilmun people on the islands of Failaka and Bahrain in the Persian Gulf. In these parts, the Harappans were known as the people of Meluhha—possibly close to a name the Harappans had for their own territory—and were perhaps seen as a source of luxury goods like carnelian beads, lapis lazuli, gold dust, ivory, pearls, fine timber and exotic animals. The Harappans may have returned with dates, wool textiles, incense and more.

All this trade appears to have been led by the Harappans, who built seagoing vessels that went along the coast to Mesopotamia. Based on surviving terracotta models from the nearby trading port of Lothal (then on the sea), these vessels include a sailboat, 'a flat-bottomed barge-like boat', 'a heavy boat, with a broad stern, and pointed prow' and a catamaran.[23] These and other innovations in seafaring may have happened at Dholavira and Lothal. A ship depicted on a seal shows a central cabin and two land-seeking birds. Many of their ships were large and sturdy enough to even transport water buffaloes to Mesopotamia, for which there is inferential evidence. Some Akkadian seals refer to an expat community of Harappans in Mesopotamia. One describes the owner of the seal as 'Silusu, interpreter of Meluhha language'. A Sumerian-style burial found in Harappa suggests that Mesopotamians lived in that city too.[24]